Breakfast

By Norman A. Bert

(A CUSTOMER enters the coffee shop. She pauses only long enough to see the table before going to sit at it. The WAITRESS approaches.)

WAITRESS: Good morning.

CUSTOMER: Hi.

WAITRESS: Would you like to see a menu?

CUSTOMER: No, that won't be necessary; I know exactly what I want.

INTRODUCTION

WAITRESS: So many choices
CUSTOMER: selections
WAITRESS: options
CUSTOMER: alternatives
WAITRESS: And it's only…
BOTH: Breakfast
CUSTOMER: by Norman A. Bert

WAITRESS: *(Taking her order pad and pencil from a hip pocket)* Fine. Coffee - or tea?

CUSTOMER: Coffee, please.

WAITRESS: Regular of decaf?

CUSTOMER: Regular.

WAITRESS: White or black?

CUSTOMER: White, please.

WAITRESS: Milk, cream, or non-dairy whitener?

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CUSTOMER: Milk.

WAITRESS: Whole, skim, or two-per?

CUSTOMER: Two-per.

WAITRESS: Sugar?

CUSTOMER: Artificial sweetener, please.

WAITRESS: Liquid or powder?

CUSTOMER: Oh, you have liquid sweetener? Yes, liquid, please.

WAITRESS: *(Writing it down)* Fine. And now, something to eat?

CUSTOMER: Yes. Cold cereal, please.

WAITRESS: *(Writing it down)* Cold cereal. What kind, ma'am?

CUSTOMER: Oh, it doesn't matter. Just bring anything.

WAITRESS: I'm sorry, but I can't do that. My job is to serve you; your job is to make the decisions. I don't get paid enough to make customers' decisions.

CUSTOMER: OK. No problem. What have you got?

WAITRESS: Well, we're not a supermarket. We have a limited selection of the most popular brands. Just tell me what you want; chances are, we got it.

CUSTOMER: No, no, no. *Tempt* me. Come on, give me the list.

WAITRESS: *(Sighing)* OK. We got granola and milled. Natural, regular, and strictly artificial. Oat, wheat, rice, corn, barley, and combinations. With fruit and without. Sugared and not sugared. With saccharin and/or Nutrasweet. Kellogg's, Post, Quaker, General Mills, Checker-Board-Square, Nabisco, Malt-O-Meal, and generic.

CUSTOMER: That's a *limited* selection?

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WAITRESS: This ain't New York, lady. What can I tell ya? If it's not enough choices, a new shipment comes in on Tuesday.

CUSTOMER: Well, I can't cope with all that. Just bring me some bran cereal.

WAITRESS: Bran.

CUSTOMER: Yeah. You have bran?

WAITRESS: Yeah, we got bran. Flakes or "all-bran" variety?

CUSTOMER: What?

WAITRESS: Do ya want the kinda bran that's in flakes, or do ya want the kinda wormy looking stuff. Sorry. Not a nice choice of words, but that's always what it looks like to me.

CUSTOMER: Oh, the cat-food-looking stuff.

WAITRESS: Yeah, that's it. Cat food. Gotta remember that. Sounds better than "wormy looking."

CUSTOMER: Yes. That's fine. I'll take that kind. I mean, that's the real thing, isn't it? I mean, if you're going to eat healthy, you might as well go all the way, huh?

WAITRESS: Yeah, well, that's up to you. Me, I eat to live. Live and enjoy. Far as I can see, if you eat what you like, you'll eventually get it all, you know?

CUSTOMER: Maybe. I'm not so sure. Anyhow, I'll have the wormy kind of bran.

WAITRESS: Good. That narrows it down. Now we got your Real Bran, your Extra Bran, and your Total Bran.

CUSTOMER: Oh my God. What's the difference? Just bring me one of them!

WAITRESS: Like I said, lady. They don't pay me to make decisions. It can only get me in trouble.

CUSTOMER: OK. So what are they again?

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WAITRESS: Real Bran, Extra Bran, and Total Bran.

CUSTOMER: I don't know. What's the difference?

WAITRESS: Well, for one thing, they differ in the amount of dietary fiber which is the bulk stuff why people eat bran in the first place.

CUSTOMER: Yeah?

WAITRESS: Yeah. Now your Total Bran has twelve grams of fiber per serving while your Extra Bran only has ten and your Real Bran's got only nine.

CUSTOMER: Well, that solves it then, doesn't it? I'll take the ...

WAITRESS: Hold it, hold it. Don't you want to know about the sugar? I mean, if you're gonna be healthy, you ought to consider the sugar, too, right?

CUSTOMER: Yeah, OK. So tell me about the sugar.

WAITRESS: Well, they all got it in one form or another. Extra Bran's got six grams per serving; Real Bran's got five grams, and Total Bran's only got two grams.

CUSTOMER: Well, that settles it then for sure.

WAITRESS: Maybe.

CUSTOMER: Maybe?

WAITRESS: Take it from me, the Total Bran needs more sugar. I watch the customers, see, and most of the Total Bran eaters, after one or two bites, they put on a little sugar. They're pretty sneaky about it, but I don't miss much. You put a half teaspoon of sugar on, and you're right up there with the Real Bran and Extra.

CUSTOMER: Oh, wow. Well, let me see. I...

WAITRESS: Yeah, and while you're working on that, you might also consider that your Real Bran's got two hundred sixty milligrams of sodium while

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your Extra and Total have a hundred and ninety milligrams and two hundred thirty, respectively. Not counting the milk, that is. 'Course I don't know if you're concerned about that or not.

CUSTOMER: No, I'm not.

WAITRESS: Fine. They're *your* arteries. Anyhow, like I always say, how can soft food make hard arteries, right?

CUSTOMER: So, you mean to choose my cereal, I have to strike some kind of a balance between my bowels, my heart, and my arteries?

WAITRESS: Yeah, that's it. Least that's one way to look at it. Or you can think of it this way - choosing between going fast with a coronary, being paralyzed then zapped again for good with a stroke, or sort of lengthening it out with cancer, you know?

CUSTOMER: This is getting harder and harder. Say you know what you ought to do? You ought to make up a chart with the various kinds of cereal and all the variables so people could see it all at a glance and make up their minds that way.

WAITRESS: Do you know how much space that would take up, lady? It'd be a book. I mean we haven't even started on the various vitamin contents and all. And then, if we got into the fruities and sweeties and spookies and other novelty cereals, well, it would just be *impossible.*

CUSTOMER: Maybe you could computerize it. I mean, you could get *rich.* Put *all* the cereals in this program and sell it to restaurants.

WAITRESS: I dunno. You know what kind of turn-over there is in the cereal market? Every month there are a few new ones and a couple of the old ones bite the dust.

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CUSTOMER: So much the better. For an annual fee, you agree to up-date everyone's program monthly. Just think of the possibilities. You could get out of this joint and be on your own.

WAITRESS: What's the matter with this joint? I sort of like it here. Besides, how many restaurants got computers anyway?

CUSTOMER: You might be surprised. And if they haven't got them now, they'll get them soon.

WAITRESS: Dunno much about computers, but I can tell you one reason it wouldn't work: taste. When everything's said and done, most people choose a cereal 'cause they just like it. That's individual. You can't computerize taste.

CUSTOMER: I think you could quantify it. You just ask the customer, "On a scale of one to ten, how crunchy do you like your cereal, with one being over-cooked oatmeal, and ten being dry granola?" And then you punch the answer in and say, "OK, and on a scale of one to ten with ten being pure sugar and one being like water, how sweet do you like your cereal?" Then you punch *that* in and...

WAITRESS: OK, I get the point. Maybe it's possible.

CUSTOMER: It's just a choice. If it's a choice, you can quantify it. Choices come from a balancing of variables. Computers can handle variables.

WAITRESS: Dunno. I still think the *customer* should be able to decide.

CUSTOMER: And speaking of choices, I'd design it for the IBM Pc.

WAITRESS: IBM PC?

CUSTOMER: Yeah, the computer, you know?

WAITRESS: Oh, the IBM PC's a computer.

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CUSTOMER: Yeah. Although you might want to consider Apple. There are millions of Macs out there. They're more userfriendly.

WAITRESS: User-friendly. Well, that should probably go into making the choice.

CUSTOMER: Oh yeah, for sure. 'Course if you want cheap, there's Dell. Or Compaq. And then there's Gateway and Toshiba and Cybertron and Alienware and Packard-Bell and H-P and N-E-C and A-B-S and ...

WAITRESS: Hold it, hold it, hold it. I can't get into this! I got enough problems. Forget the computers.

CUSTOMER: You mean you choose to ignore the whole wave of the future?

WAITRESS: Yeah. Should I feel guilty or something?

CUSTOMER: No. That's cool. It's your choice.

WAITRESS: Fine. Now can we get back to your cereal?

CUSTOMER: Look I can't deal with this cereal thing. Just bring me an egg and toast.

WAITRESS: *(Scratching off "cereal" on her order pad and writing "egg w/T")* OK. You want that egg over, up, scrambled, poached, or boiled?

CUSTOMER: Uh. Up, I think. No - over. Yes, definitely over.

WAITRESS: Hard or runny?

CUSTOMER: Just so the white won't and the yolk will, if you know what I mean.

WAITRESS: No problem. White, wheat, or rye toast, bran muffin, English muffin, or bagel?

CUSTOMER: Wheat toast.

WAITRESS: Anything else?

CUSTOMER: No, that should be just fine.

WAITRESS: Fine. Be back with your coffee in a minute.

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CUSTOMER: Thanks. *(The WAITER exits.)*

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